

Language Report: Dukhan

1.Introduction

The Dukhan language (dukh1234) , referred to by its speakers as *tu^hha sös* ('Dukhan language'), is the native tongue of the Dukha people, a nomadic Turkic tribe residing in the northern part of Mongolia. The language is critically endangered, with only around 40 speakers remaining today. The Dukha people are reindeer herders, and this is reflected in the language's extensive reindeer-related lexicon. Genetically, Dukhan belongs to the Sayan group of the Siberian branch of the Turkic language family. The speakers are currently bilingual in Dukhan and Darkhat Mongolian, a situation that only began in the 1950s. Despite this contact, Dukhan retains features that are characteristically Turkic.

2. Some of the syntactic characteristics of the language

2.1. Alignment Type

Dukhan exhibits a nominative-accusative alignment in its inflectional morphology, while a split ergative-absolutive alignment is observed in its derivational morphology.

(1) a. Intransitive Verb

Irey pol-sa on pir ay-da utu-ur

bear sleep-3SG eleven month LOC sleep-INTRA.LF

"As for the bear, it sleeps in month eleven."

(Ragagnin 2011:147)

b. Transitive Verb

Tayga ulus-tar-ə güs-ən thos ay-da tongər jahsa-ar.

taiga people-PL-POSS3 autumn-ADV.DER nine month-LOC reindeer calf castrate-INTRA.LF

"Taiga people castrate reindeer bucks in month nine."

(Ragagnin 2011:147)

These examples illustrate the nominative case used for both intransitive and transitive subjects. In the first sentence, "Irey" ('bear') is the intransitive subject, and in the second, "Tayga uləs-tar-ə" ('Taiga people') is the transitive agent, both unmarked nominative.

(2) Ol purən šay-dan peerə gahhay-nə tayga uləs-tar-ə thödə hereyle-p tur-ar

That previous time-ABL since cradle-ACC taiga people-PL-POSS3 all use-CB stand-INTRA.LF

"Since those former times, all of the taiga peoples use the hanging cradle." (Ragagnin 2011:123)

This sentence demonstrates accusative case marking on the direct object "gahhay-nə" ('cradle'), identified with the accusative suffix -nə. The nominative subject "tayga uləs-tar-ə" acts on the marked object.

(3) ün-ěš

(3a) tanə-š

come.out-NMLZ

know-NMLZ

"plant" (lit. 'the thing that comes out')

"acquaintance" (lit. 'the known person')

(3b) ahk-îm

(3c) ĵe-m

(3d) poluu-škən

(3e) oyńaa-škən

flow-NMLZ

eat-NMLZ

happen-NMLZ

play-NMLZ

"current"

"meal"

"events"

"game"

(Ragagnin 2011:91)

These forms demonstrate that in derivational morphology, S and P align together (absolutive-like behavior), while A is not directly marked. The conditioning factor for this split alignment is the morphological domain (inflection vs. derivation), not NP-type, T/A/M, or verb-type.

2.2. Constituent Order

Dukhan follows a consistent Subject-Object-Verb (SOV) word order.

(4) Ol purən šay-dan peerə gahhay-nə tayga uləs-tar-ə thödə hereyle-p tur-ar

That previous time-ABL since cradle-ACC taiga people-PL-POSS3 all use-CB stand-INTRA.LF

(Ragagnin 2011:123)

"Since those former times, all of the taiga peoples use the hanging cradle."

In this declarative clause, the order of elements is clearly SOV: the subject "tayga uləs-tar-ə" ('Taiga people'), the object "gahhay-nə" ('cradle'), and the verb phrase "hereyle-p tur-ar" ('use').

2.2.a. Attributive Adjective and Noun

Attributive adjectives precede the noun. a typical A-N order common in SOV languages.

(5) ekkə aht

good horse "a good horse"

(Ragagnin 2011:89)

2.2.b. Demonstrative and Noun

Demonstratives also precede the noun.

(6) po tayga

(7) ol tayga

(8) tee tayga

this taiga

that taiga

that taiga (over there)

(Ragagnin 2011:99)

These patterns (A N and Dem N) conform to the left-branching syntax typical of Turkic languages and SOV word order languages more generally.

3. References

Christopher Moseley. 2010. Atlas of the World's Languages in Danger
Elisabetta Ragagnin. 2011. Dukhan, a Turkic Variety of Northern Mongolia
Description and Analysis

4. Gloss

INTRA : intraterminal

LF : low-focal

CB : converb